

should deal with a complex system with opaque causal links and complicated interactions. Mother Nature is not perfect, but has so far proven smarter than humans, certainly much smarter than biologists. So my approach is to combine evidence-based research (stripped of biological theory), with an a priori that Mother Nature has more authority than anyone.

After my “Aha!” flash, I embarked on an Extremistan barbell lifestyle under the guidance of Art De Vany: long, very long, slow, meditative (or conversational) walks in a stimulating urban setting, but with occasional (and random) very short sprints, during which I made myself angry imagining I was chasing the bankster Robert Rubin with a big stick, trying to catch him and bring him to human justice. I went to weight-lifting facilities in a random way for a completely stochastic workout—typically in hotels, when I was on the road. Like Gray Swan events, these were very, very rare, but highly consequential weight-lifting periods, after a day of semistarvation, leaving me completely exhausted. Then I would be totally sedentary for weeks and hang around cafés. Even the duration of the workouts remained random—but most often very short, less than fifteen minutes. I followed the path that minimized boredom, and remained very polite with gym employees who described my workouts as “erratic.” I put myself through thermal variability as well, exposed, on occasion, to extreme cold without a coat. Thanks to transcontinental travel and jet lag, I underwent periods of sleep deprivation followed by excessive rest. When I went to places with good restaurants, for instance Italy, I ate in quantities that would have impressed Fat Tony himself, then skipped meals for a while without suffering. Then, after two and a half years of this apparently “unhealthy” regimen, I saw significant changes in my own physique on every possible criterion—the absence of unnecessary adipose tissue, the blood pressure of a twenty-one-year-old, and so on. I also have a clearer, much more acute mind.

So the main idea is to trade duration for intensity—for a hedonic gain. Recall the reasoning I presented in [Chapter 6](#) about hedonic effects. Just as people prefer large but sudden losses to small but regular ones, just as one becomes dulled to pain beyond a certain threshold, so unpleasant experiences, like working out without external stimuli (say in a gym), or spending time in New Jersey, need to be as concentrated and as intense as possible.

Another way to view the connection to the Black Swan idea is as follows. Classical thermodynamics produces Gaussian variations, while informational variations are from Extremistan. Let me explain. If you